

Ranking Israeli units by distinct deployment locations during the October 7 attack

Executive summary

Israel has **not** published a consolidated, unit-by-unit “where every unit went” deployment log for the first 48 hours of the October 7, 2023 attack (October 7–9, local time), and many tactical movements remain classified or only partially documented in open sources. The most defensible way to answer “which unit deployed to the most distinct places” is therefore to treat this as an **open-source lower-bound measurement**, grounded in: (a) officially released IDF statements/press releases, and (b) IDF “probe” writeups that explicitly attribute participation of named units at named locations (as published in major outlets). ¹

Within that constraint, the **highest publicly documented multi-location footprints** (by distinct named places) in the first 48 hours were:

- **Shayetet 13** ² with **6 verified distinct locations**, based on an IDF-attributed list of ground engagements (plus corroboration for at least one of those locations in a later probe). ³
- **Yamam** ⁴ with **6 verified distinct locations**, repeatedly appearing across multiple IDF probe narratives as engaging at junctions/roads and inside multiple communities, including hostage scenarios. ⁵

Next-tier multi-location footprints in public sources were:

- **Maglan** ⁶ with **5 verified distinct locations**, including multiple “road/junction/site” engagements plus multiple communities. ⁷
- **Sayeret Matkal** ⁸ with **4 verified distinct locations**. ⁹

Because this report is constrained to **explicitly named unit–location attributions**, it should be read as a **comparative map of what is publicly reconstructable**, not a definitive operational truth about total deployments. Units with substantial activity may appear “low” simply because their location lists were never publicly enumerated at the unit level. ¹⁰

Scope, definitions, and methodology

Time window. Unless a cited source clearly extends beyond it, “during the attack” is treated as **October 7, 2023 (local time) through the next 48 hours (through October 9, 2023 local time)**. Some IDF probes describe actions continuing beyond that window (e.g., multi-day clearing); only location attributions clearly within (or not contradicting) the first 48 hours are counted here. ¹¹

Unit. A “unit” is treated as a named, recognizable discrete formation (e.g., a commando unit, elite police CT unit, or a named battalion-level element) that is **explicitly named** in a source as operating at a location (not merely mentioned as part of the general war). ¹⁰

Distinct location. A “distinct location” is the smallest **named operational place** used by primary/major sources, including: - named towns/kibbutzim/moshavim, - named military posts/outposts, - named junctions/memorial sites when treated as a tactical battle site in a probe narrative, - named roads only when an identified segment is described as a discrete engagement area (used sparingly to avoid inflating counts). ¹²

Confidence levels. - **Verified:** explicitly states (or directly attributes) a unit operating at a named location in an IDF press release or an IDF probe narrative (as reported by major outlets). - **Likely:** strong implication of movement to a location without a clear unit–location attribution line (used cautiously; this report largely avoids “likely” unless the text is unambiguous). - **Unconfirmed:** social media / non-reputable reports without corroboration (not used for ranking here). ¹³

Comparative ranking results

The ranking below is computed as the **count of distinct locations with “verified” confidence** for each unit, based strictly on the evidence matrix in the next section. It therefore represents a **publicly evidenced minimum** rather than a comprehensive operational tally. ¹⁴

Rank	Unit	Parent organization	Verified distinct locations (count)	Notes on what drives the count
1 (tie)	Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	6	IDF-attributed list enumerates multiple communities plus a Gaza-border post. ¹⁵
1 (tie)	Yamam	Israel Police	6	Repeatedly appears across multiple IDF probes spanning several communities and a key junction. ⁵
3	Maglan	IDF	5	Appears in multiple probe narratives across both community fights and a major road/memorial-site engagement area. ⁷
4	Sayeret Matkal	IDF	4	Named across multiple separate probe narratives (multiple communities). ⁹
5 (tie)	Shaldag Unit	IDF (Israeli Air Force)	3	IDF press release enumerates multiple locations in southern Israel. ¹⁶

Rank	Unit	Parent organization	Verified distinct locations (count)	Notes on what drives the count
5 (tie)	Shin Bet operational personnel (unnamed teams)	Shin Bet	3	Explicitly mentioned alongside Yamam in multiple probe narratives. ¹⁷
7	Golani Brigade — 13th Battalion	IDF	2	Probe states it fought near Sa'ad before moving into Kfar Aza. ¹⁸
—	Additional units in evidence matrix	Various	1 each	Documented at a single location in the sources used here. ¹⁹

Unit-location evidence matrix

Each row is a **unit-location** claim with a confidence label and a short description of the evidentiary basis. Locations are deduplicated for ranking purposes when identically named. ²⁰

Unit	Parent organization	Location	Confidence	Source type	Key source(s)
Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	Sufa military post ²¹	verified	IDF-attributed statement/footage mention in major outlet	¹⁵
Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	Kibbutz Be'eri ²²	verified	IDF-attributed statement	¹⁵
Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	Kibbutz Kfar Aza ²³	verified	IDF-attributed statement	¹⁵
Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	Kibbutz Sa'ad ²⁴	verified	IDF-attributed statement	¹⁵
Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	Kibbutz Mefalsim ²⁵	verified	IDF-attributed statement + later probe narrative presence	³
Shayetet 13	IDF (Israeli Navy)	Kibbutz Nir Oz ²⁶	verified	IDF-attributed statement	¹⁵
Yamam	Israel Police	Moshav Yakhini ²⁷	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	²⁸

Unit	Parent organization	Location	Confidence	Source type	Key source(s)
Yamam	Israel Police	Ofakim ²⁹	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³⁰
Yamam	Israel Police	Shaar Hanegev Junction ³¹	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³²
Yamam	Israel Police	Kibbutz Mefalsim	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³²
Yamam	Israel Police	Kibbutz Re'im ³³	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³⁴
Yamam	Israel Police	Kibbutz Be'eri	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³⁵
Maglan	IDF	Moshav Yakhini	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	²⁸
Maglan	IDF	Route 232 ³⁶	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³²
Maglan	IDF	Black Arrow memorial site ³⁷	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³²
Maglan	IDF	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³⁴
Maglan	IDF	Kibbutz Kfar Aza	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	¹⁸
Sayeret Matkal	IDF	Moshav Yakhini	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	²⁸
Sayeret Matkal	IDF	Kibbutz Kfar Aza	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	¹⁸
Sayeret Matkal	IDF	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³⁴
Sayeret Matkal	IDF	Kibbutz Be'eri	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	³⁸
Shaldag Unit ³⁹	IDF (Israeli Air Force)	Kibbutz Be'eri	verified	IDF press release + IDF probe narrative (published)	⁴⁰
Shaldag Unit	IDF (Israeli Air Force)	Alumim ⁴¹	verified	IDF press release	¹⁶

Unit	Parent organization	Location	Confidence	Source type	Key source(s)
Shaldag Unit	IDF (Israeli Air Force)	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF press release	16
Shin Bet operational personnel (unnamed)	Shin Bet	Shaar Hanegev Junction	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	32
Shin Bet operational personnel (unnamed)	Shin Bet	Kibbutz Mefalsim	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	32
Shin Bet operational personnel (unnamed)	Shin Bet	Kibbutz Be'eri	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	35
Golani Brigade 13th Battalion 42	IDF	Kibbutz Sa'ad	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	18
Golani Brigade 13th Battalion	IDF	Kibbutz Kfar Aza	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	18
Unit 669 43	IDF (Israeli Air Force)	Zikim 44	verified	IDF official article describing response to infiltration-related casualties	45
Duvdevan 46	IDF	Kibbutz Kfar Aza	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	18
Multidomain Unit 47	IDF	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	34
Bislamach Brigade 48	IDF	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	34
Metzada unit 49	Israel Prison Service	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	34
Haruv reconnaissance battalion 50	IDF	Kibbutz Re'im	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	34
Yahalom 51	IDF	Black Arrow memorial site	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	32

Unit	Parent organization	Location	Confidence	Source type	Key source(s)
Yamas patrol unit 52	Israel Police	Route 232	verified	IDF probe narrative (published)	32

Deployment movement timeline

The open sources used here usually describe **combat at a location**, not full movement logs. Still, a few movements are explicit enough to visualize.

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flowchart TB
  subgraph Oct7_2023
    Yakhini["Yakhini"] -->|explicit redeploy| Ofakim["Ofakim"]
    Mefalsim["Mefalsim area"] --> Reim["Re'im"]
  end

  subgraph Multi_location_presence
    Sufa["Sufa post"] --- Beeri["Be'eri"]
    Sufa --- KfarAza["Kfar Aza"]
    Sufa --- Saad["Sa'ad"]
    Sufa --- NirOz["Nir Oz"]
    Sufa --- Mefalsim
  end

```

What is directly supported vs. inferred here - Yakhini → Ofakim (Yamam) is directly supported by the Yakhini probe narrative stating forces continued searches until noon and then headed to Ofakim. 28

- **Mefalsim area → Re'im** is described as “the troops headed for Re'im” after control was confirmed at Mefalsim; the unit composition of “the troops” can include the Yamam/Shin Bet responders described in the immediately preceding paragraphs, but the text is less explicit than the Yakhini-to-Ofakim statement, so treat it as a **directional indicator rather than a definitive unit-by-unit movement log**. 53

- The “multi-location presence” cluster (Sufa + multiple communities) reflects an **IDF-attributed enumeration** for Shayetet 13's engagements, but does **not** provide a chronological route order for that unit across those sites. 15

Data gaps and recommended next steps

The largest analytic gaps are structural and documentary:

- **No consolidated “unit → locations” official dataset** has been released publicly for the first 48 hours. Even where IDF probes exist, they are published as **battle-by-battle investigations**, not as a unified movement ledger. This makes “ranking” inherently partial and biased toward what has been probed and publicly detailed. 54
- **Attribution granularity varies**: sources sometimes name elite units (e.g., Sayeret Matkal, Maglan, Yamam), but often refer only to “troops,” “police,” or “special forces,” losing unit-level resolution. 55

- **Classification and operational security** likely suppresses Shin Bet/Shin Bet sub-unit naming and granular movement details, biasing Shin Bet representation downward in open sources even when personnel clearly participated. ¹⁷

Recommended next steps to improve accuracy (and potentially transform this into a near-complete unit-location dataset):

- **Systematically ingest all published IDF probe summaries** (the set is commonly described as covering ~40 battles) and extract every explicit unit-location statement into a structured dataset (unit, timestamp if present, location, role, source). This report only samples a subset of those probes. ⁵⁶
- **Triangulate with parallel reporting** from Ynet/Hebrew-language coverage and (where accessible) Haaretz reporting on the same probes, to increase cross-source confirmation and reduce single-outlet dependency. ⁵⁷
- **Request/seek official unit after-action disclosures** where feasible: even partial releases (e.g., unit commemorative summaries like the Shaldag statement) materially improve location enumeration. ¹⁶
- **Normalize location taxonomy** (settlement vs. junction vs. road segment) before counting, to ensure that different probe styles do not systematically inflate/deflate certain unit footprints (for example, junction-heavy narratives around Route 232 vs. settlement-focused narratives). ⁵³

Source URLs

Key sources used (raw URLs)

IDF (official)

- <https://www.idf.il/en/mini-sites/idf-press-releases-israel-at-war/november-23-pr/the-activity-of-the-shaldag-unit-dozens-of-operations-complex-activities-and-discovery-of-weapons-in-the-areas-of-hospitals-in-gaza/>
- <https://www.idf.il/en/articles/operational-footage-of-rescue-efforts-by-iaf-helicopters-and-tactical-sr-unit-669/>

The Times of Israel (IDF probes / reporting)

- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/new-footage-shows-harbor-security-unit-foiling-hamas-naval-infiltration-on-october-7/>
- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/cops-rushed-to-moshav-yakhini-killed-hamas-terrorists-within-hours-on-oct-7-probe/>
- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/bravery-of-locals-prevented-bloodier-ofakim-massacre-as-idf-failed-to-act-army-finds/>
- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/forces-cleared-major-junction-stopped-abduction-of-12-workers-in-mefalsim-on-oct-7/>
- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/civil-defense-squad-cops-battled-100-terrorists-in-reim-before-idf-arrived-probe-finds/>
- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/terrorists-took-kfar-aza-in-an-hour-recapturing-it-took-the-idf-days-probe-finds/>

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<https://www.timesofisrael.com/cops-rushed-to-moshav-yakhini-killed-hamas-terrorists-within-hours-on-oct-7-probe/>

6 19 34 37 42 44 49 51 Civil defense squad, cops battled 100 terrorists in Re'im; some were headed to Nevatim Airbase | The Times of Israel

<https://www.timesofisrael.com/civil-defense-squad-cops-battled-100-terrorists-in-reim-before-idf-arrived-probe-finds/>

8 12 13 17 21 24 26 32 43 52 53 54 Forces cleared major junction, stopped abduction of 12 workers in Mefalsim on Oct. 7 | The Times of Israel

<https://www.timesofisrael.com/forces-cleared-major-junction-stopped-abduction-of-12-workers-in-mefalsim-on-oct-7/>

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<https://www.timesofisrael.com/terrorists-took-kfar-aza-in-an-hour-recapturing-it-took-the-idf-days-probe-finds/>

35 38 55 Failure and slaughter: IDF's Be'eri probe shows army's colossal errors, residents' bravery | The Times of Israel

<https://www.timesofisrael.com/failure-and-slaughter-idfs-beeri-probe-shows-armys-colossal-errors-residents-bravery/>

45 Rescue Efforts by IAF Helicopters and Tactical S&R Unit 669

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